The Janitor

By Rick Najera

INTRODUCTION

The attacks on the World Trade Center brought America together. Our diverse nation flew the American flag, donated blood and gathered for candlelight vigils ***together****. On the steps of the Capitol, Republicans and Democrats in Congress sang "God Bless America" as one voice. Our country was united.*

But not today . . . today instead of being united by real threats, we're being divided from within by partisan issues: health care, the environment, immigration. Immigration . . . New York City, ground zero for the 9/11 attacks, is today desperately trying to protect their undocumented workers from deportation by federal ICE officials. In fact, the city has banned the use of "illegals" or "illegal aliens" as discriminatory.

In this selection, we travel back to 2001, back to NYC and back to ground zero through the eyes of Carlos . . . . . The Janitor by Rick Najera

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(In the darkness we hear a man whistling a tune. He is dressed as a Dominican janitor. Behind him, he wheels in a janitor dolly filled with cleaning supplies. Throughout his monologue, he is clearning: mopping, trash, dusting, etc)

CARLOS: *(To audience)* Sorry. I'm not important. I clean here, that's what I do here. You make a mess and I'll clean it, but I clean real good you know? I clean real good. When I was a kid in Dominican Republic, people would say, "Hey, Carlos what are you going to do when you grow up?" "Oh, I'm going to clean things, 'cause I clean very good:" Besides, I was the only Dominican kid that couldn't play baseball; I had to clean. But I was always ambitious. I always wanted to come to the United States of America and be a janitor. At least I found my occupation. I clean -- that's what I do. I clean very good. I clean very, very good. People they say to me, "Carlos you're in America now, in America we use chemicals." Chemicals, chemicals, chemicals. Okay! I got a cart full of chemicals, but

sometimes the natural stuff works the best.

(To a specific person in the audience) Oh man, you look like you like to drink your tequila every once in a while. You mix it, you throw up . . . nothing cleans up vomit better than sawdust, and if it's cedar sawdust, even better. Write it down. That's a trade secret I just gave you. Sawdust for vomit, okay?

(Back to general audience) When I first came to America, I had a good job. I got a job as an elementary school janitor. That was a good job. I used a lot of sawdust there. Flu season or chili day? I saw some bad things; I don't like to talk about that. This one kid he threw up so bad . . . the wall was like a mural. It was like the Sistine Chapel but with Captain Crunch and Fruit Loops. ***Ay carajo!*** I got a promotion after that. They made me high school janitor. Ay, that was a good job. High school janitor. They actually gave me a master key to all the kids' lockers and when they were in class I would go in and steal their marijuana. You smoke one of those marijuana cigarettes and those fish tacos from the cafeteria taste gourmet. High school janitor; that was a good job, man!

. . . I had to get out of high school; too much violence in high school. That Columbine thing scared the crap out of me, man. When white kids go bad, they plan it. 9 a.m.: kill classmates. 9:10 a.m.: kill teachers. 10:20 a.m.: kill myself. **Ay carajo!** That won't happen in a Latino school. I guarantee that won't happen in Latino school. 'Cause they'll never get there at the same time. One will show up at 9, one at 3, one at 5 . . . One won't show up and have a really good excuse the next day why he missed the shootout.

. . . I got out of high school. After that I got my dream job. I got my dream job in the city; I work in one of those big office buildings. Easy work. Easy. All

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I had to do was clean 20 floors at night and 20 floors during the day;

I made a lot of overtime there. ***Mucha guardo. Mucha dinero.*** I even met a girl. She worked at the restaurant upstairs; I worked downstairs. We would meet halfway.

I like living in the city and working in the city. 'Cause I would see all kinds of things. I'd walk in on bosses having sex with their secretaries and sometimes just having sex by themselves . . . ***Sinverguenzas***!

Oh, the girl I was telling you about? She was from Honduras. I fell in love with her and I wanted to marry her and I did. I was so happy because if you can make it as a janitor in NYC, you can make it anywhere. *(Beat.)* I remember those buildings.

(Lights go up on stage. Reveal two simple beams of light against the wall resembling the Twin Towers.)

I was cleaning up that morning when the first plane hit. Ay, what a mess. There was smoke and dust everywhere. Then the second plane hit. Then they fell. My big beautiful buildings fell to the ground. I lost a lot of friends there: other janitors, busboys, and dishwashers from the restaurant upstairs. A lot of Latinos. But you're not going to hear about them on the reports. They were not reported because they were illegal aliens. Why do people have to make messes that they can never clean up? I stayed and helped with the clean-up and a big man comes to me and says, "Why are you here? You're not a fireman:' And I said, "I clean, sir. That's what I do.

I clean. And I'm going to be here until there's nothing left to clean up. Or until I find my wife.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2017 National Qualifier
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